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Keller Hut Snow Weekend

Kim along with some leaders we know in Sierra Club planned a beginner snow weekend up in the nearby mountains. The idea was to use one of the Sierra Club cabins and give participants the option of doing snowboarding, skiing, snow shoeing, cross country, or just sitting around in the snow.

Kim and I had originally planned to head out Friday night but due to some work complications we stole a few short hours of sleep and took off early early Saturday morning. We were already sleep deprived and the preparation and flight from my apartment was full of minor mishaps such as tripping over a curb and going flying through the air with a full cooler (thankfully no beer was hurt and I heal but the eggs were a goner.)

We had had a fairly good storm a few days previous so we expected to have to use chains. My truck was having issues with the heater so I was driving Kim's car. I'd actually never put on or driven with chains but there's a first time for everything.



We were the first to arrive except for Fran and George who had come out the night before.



This is the driveway shared by Keller Hut and two other cabins. It was obviously not doable in Kim's car chains or not so we ended up parking across the main road at Snow Valley ski resort and walking along an icy road, arms full of gear, while cars flew past and honked at us.



On the plus side everything was absolutely beautiful with fresh fluffy snow everywhere. It was a bit on the cold side and I was just waiting for a car to slide out of control and hit us but that just kept things interesting.



From the top of the driveway we followed a foot path through the snow that had been established by Fran and George the night before. The cabin above is Keller Hut itself, which is another one of the Sierra Club properties which anyone can stay at for a small fee assuming an overseer is present.

Sleeping is done upstairs in a dorm like area with thin pallets on the floor. That is, unless you're Matt and you build your own bed downstairs:



It's a bit on the rustic side, particularly this weekend because the pipes had frozen leaving us with no functional toilets. George and Fran eventually got them thawed but you still had to melt a bucket of snow on the stove, bring the bucket into the bathroom with you, and then when you were done with your business pour the bucket with some force into the bowl and hopefully watch it flush.

Heat is provided by wood stoves; that is assuming you can get into the wood shed out back which proved to be somewhat difficult.

It did have a surprisingly functional kitchen complete with a microwave which maybe one of the original models ever released commercially. I tried to hide my reproductive bits behind foil every time I used it.

Note the pots on the stove, those were constantly in use the entire trip being filled with snow, melted, emptied, and refilled since we didn't have running water for a good portion of the trip. There was also no shortage of extra pots or silverware since they had quite the collection going.



While we waited for others to arrive I did my best to make myself useful by grabbing a snow shovel and digging the path and a few parking spaces at the top of the hill out from under a surprising amount of snow.

Other began to arrive in a variety of vehicles. Gigi had a 4 wheel drive and managed to make it up the snowy driveway only getting stuck briefly. Later we tried to get Mark's 2 wheel drive SUV up and ran into a bit of a snag...



It became stuck about halfway up. After much digging we managed to free it and he almost made it back to the road only to get caught in another snow bank right at the entrance.



More digging followed along with an interesting attempt to tow him out using a Jeep with a winch sliding around on an icy road as traffic zoomed by and honked. I was ready with pictures and video in case there was an interesting accident (YouTube fame here I come!) but it ended with just more digging (awe, here's the much less exciting actual video:)

Eventually the vehicle was free and we decided carrying equipment from across the main road wasn't that bad.

So finally the snowboarding group headed for the slopes and another large group went out snowshoeing. Since the cross country outing had been canceled that left Kim and I with a chance to relax at the cabin for a bit.



The snowshoe party returned and Gigi was nice enough to insist Kim and I try it. She lent us her and Harold's equipment and we set out for a quick snowshoe excursion of our own with Ghia tagging along on cross country skis.



We couldn't go far because another storm was blowing in but we had a good little outing.





That night was the traditional Sierra Club potluck and of course no one went thirsty.



The storm hit but it was warm enough that night that it came down as rain instead of snow. So the next morning instead of having to dig ourselves out we had to carry equipment down the hill in the rain walking through slush.

This was particularly entertaining at the entrance of driveway because the snowplow had left us a tall pile of snow slush blocking our way. Trying to cross it we managed to get our boots stuck requiring Kim to be physically yanked out of hers.

The drive down the hill was much easier since the rain had melted the ice off the road and we didn't even need chains. All in all it was a fun weekend and a good warm-up for some of the snow events coming in March.